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TEACHER LESSON PLAN

Stories of a Great Journey

Grades 1–2 · Homeroom / General

THE 30 MINUTES

5 min	8 min	12 min	5 min
HOOK	THE BIG MOVE	ACTIVITY	CLOSING

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will learn that the Harlem Renaissance grew from the Great Migration — a great journey of Black families moving north — and that the people who made that journey created music, stories, and art that changed America. They will connect this to their own experiences of change and discover that ordinary people can do extraordinary things.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **CCSS.ELA-LITERACY RL.1.3 / RL.2.3** — Describe the connection between events; understand how characters respond to challenges
- **NCSS Standard II (Time & Continuity)** — Understand that things change over time; people make choices that affect their lives and communities
- **National Arts MU:Re7.1a** — With guidance, identify and describe how music connects to feelings and personal experiences

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Device to play a short audio clip of Bessie Smith or Louis Armstrong (freely available on YouTube or Smithsonian Folkways)
- Simple projected or printed US map showing Southern states and New York
- Differentiated student handouts (Green / Yellow / Red) — print one per student before class
- Crayons or colored pencils for drawing activities

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

A song from far away

Play 60 seconds of Bessie Smith or a Harlem-era jazz recording. Let students simply listen with eyes closed.

"Close your eyes and just listen. What do you feel? What pictures do you see in your mind?"

Take two or three responses, then:

"This music is almost 100 years old! It was made by people who had just finished one of the longest, bravest journeys in American history. Today we are going to find out who they were — and what they made."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 8 MINUTES

The big move

Show the US map. Point to the Deep South, then trace a path north to New York.

"A long time ago, many Black families lived in the South of America — places like Mississippi and Georgia. Life was very hard and unfair there. So families packed everything they owned and moved north — to cities like Chicago and New York. We call this the Great Migration. When they arrived in a neighborhood called Harlem, something amazing happened: musicians, writers, poets, and painters all found each other. They started making something the world had never seen before — a Renaissance. That means a great burst of new ideas and beauty."

ACTIVITY · 12 MINUTES

Our great journey

Distribute differentiated handouts. Let students self-select their level, or assign based on your knowledge of their needs.

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Students draw their family's journey on a map outline, label where they came from and where they live now, and draw one thing their family brought with them. Sentence frames support emerging writers.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Students write about a personal experience of change, connect it to the Great Migration, and write about what they would create if they lived in Harlem in 1925.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Students write a first-person "interview" with an imaginary Great Migration traveler, then independently research one real Harlem Renaissance figure and write three facts.

Suggest: Langston Hughes, Bessie Smith, Duke Ellington, Zora Neale Hurston, Aaron Douglas, or Walter F. White.

Circulate and prompt with open questions. With 3 minutes remaining, invite two or three students to share.

CLOSING · 5 MINUTES

What they carried

"The people who made the Great Migration left behind their homes and sometimes their families. But they brought their music, their stories, their faith, and their creativity. And in Harlem, they used all of that to make something so beautiful it still lives today — in every jazz song, every poem, every painting."

DIFFERENTIATION NOTES

Green uses sentence frames and large drawing boxes — ideal for younger students or emerging writers. Yellow is independent, grade-level writing with a personal connection. Red adds historical research and first-person creative writing. Students may self-select or switch levels at any time.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more firsthand. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: Explore the full exhibition online.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance